

Letter Sounds for Kids: A Simple Parent Guide

A calm, practical introduction to the sounds letters can represent - and how to help a beginning reader practice them without turning reading into a quiz.

What are letter sounds?

Letter sounds are the sounds that written letters can represent in words. The letter **B** is called “bee,” but in **bat** it represents the beginning sound /b/. Learning to connect print with speech is one of the foundations of early reading.

Keep the goal small: your child does not need to memorize every possible sound before reading. One useful sound, a few words, and one tiny story is enough for a practice session.

Letter names and letter sounds are different

Letter names help children identify the symbols of the alphabet. Letter sounds help children use those symbols to read words. Children can learn both together, but when the goal is decoding, the sound is what lets the child move from a printed letter to a spoken word.

Example: B is the letter name. /b/ is a common sound for B. That sound appears at the beginning of **beach**, **big**, **bat**, and **boat**.

Common Beginning Letter Sounds

These are useful starting sounds for early practice. English letters can represent more than one sound, so think of this as a beginning reference, not a complete rulebook.

B**/b/**

bat, big

D**/d/**

dog, dig

F**/f/**

fish, fun

H**/h/**

hat, hop

J**/j/**

jam, jet

K**/k/**

kid, kit

L**/l/**

log, lid

M**/m/**

map, mug

N**/n/**

net, nap

P**/p/**

pig, pet

R**/r/**

red, run

S**/s/**

sun, sit

T**/t/**

top, ten

V**/v/**

van, vet

W**/w/**

wet, win

Y**/y/**

yes, yam

A note about C, G, Q, and X: some letters are less straightforward. C can represent /k/ in **cat** or /s/ in **city**. G can be /g/ in **go** or a softer sound in **gem**. Q is commonly heard with U in **queen**. X is often easiest to hear at the end of a word such as **fox**. Teach the sound needed for the words your child is reading now.

Start with the Short Vowel Sounds

Short vowels appear in many simple CVC words, which makes them especially useful when children begin blending sounds into words.

A

short a

cat, map, jam

E

short e

bed, hen, pet

I

short i

pig, sit, pin

O

short o

dog, log, hop

U

short u

sun, bug, cup

Try to keep consonant sounds clean

Adults sometimes add an extra “uh” when saying a consonant sound. For example, we may say “buh” instead of a short /b/. Keeping the sound brief makes blending easier because the child can push the sounds together without extra syllables getting in the way.

Example: for **bat**, think of three compact sounds that can slide together: /b/ + short a + /t/.

A 10-Minute Letter-Sound Routine

The LearnToReadStories method keeps practice short enough to repeat and meaningful enough to feel like reading.

1

Say one sound

Choose one useful sound and say it clearly.

2

Read a few words

Try three to six words that use the sound.

3

Read one tiny story

Meet the same words in a short, understandable story.

4

Stop while it feels good

Reread once if your child wants to, then celebrate and finish.

Where this fits in the Reading Path

Letter sounds are already part of **Level 1: First Words**. Your child does not need a separate curriculum before beginning. Use this guide as a parent reference, then practice the sounds inside real words and simple lessons.

Next step: Visit LearnToReadStories.com/first-words/ and choose one Level 1 lesson. One sound. A few words. One tiny story.